

Algorithmic sociality: a comparative ethnographic analysis of Douyin and TikTok in everyday social life

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Content-centric platforms like TikTok and Douyin reshape what it means to be social

- To be social is increasingly to be **placed in contact** by algorithms (Gillespie 2014) and their social programming power (Bucher 2018)
- Douyin and TikTok foreground these trends two **algorithmic encounter** over social network ties (Bhandari & Bimo 2022; Su 2023)
- **Scattered terms** adopted in the literature to explain these shifts: “sides” (Maddox & Gil 2023), “diffracted belonging” (Lee et al. 2022), “algorithmically woven communities (Wang et al. 2023)

Analytical angle 1

Algorithms are global structural forces, yet their meaning is locally enacted, not imposed (Siles 2023).

How does the same global, algorithmic infrastructure carry different meanings in different contexts?

- We generalize through **difference**, comparing two maximally distinct groups (older Douyin users in China vs young TikTok users in England)
- Same algorithmic system, divergent meanings: **renqing obligation** in rural China, **authenticity** claims in suburban England
- Goal: show how one algorithmic infrastructure can support a **range of socialities**

Analytical angle 2

Moral economy: ability to engage with public goods and produce something own from that (Silverstone 1994).

Three types of moral-economic work sharpen our view on the materialisation of algorithmic sociality



Legitimizing visibility

Justifying who may be seen, why, when, and how through the content feed.



Reciprocating engagement

Converting algorithmically mediated feedback into obligation — or declining to.



Emplacing community

Assembling locality and belonging from algorithmically woven networks.

Two ethnographies, juxtaposed for comparative leverage

Douyin · China

23 users aged 60–80; rural & urban; retired teachers, farmers, factory workers, entrepreneurs. Interviews + observation, Apr–Dec 2024.

TikTok · UK

30 users aged 18–24; London metro and suburbs; diverse backgrounds. Interviews, repertoire mappings, digital fieldwork, 2020–21.



Douyin: visibility legitimated through collective benefit

- Older users frame visibility as **cultural duty**, not self-promotion
- Open pursuit of fame is policed as '**forgetting one's roots**' (忘本)
- Norm enforced by audiences, not invented by beneficiaries



"This is about cultural transmission. The more views I get, the more people learn about our intangible cultural heritage. My success thus is culture's success."

— Grandpa's Crafts, 74, palm-weaver



TikTok: visibility legitimated through authenticity

- Young users **resist growth optimisation** as inauthentic
- Visibility valued in **qualitative**, expressive terms — not as entrepreneurial investment
- Same affordance, different moral order: ambition is allowed to mean something else



"I don't spend too much time looking at analytics ... videos about growing your following ... I'm not interested really in that kind of stuff."

— Rhea, 23, London



Douyin: reciprocity becomes a binding duty

- Likes operate as **renqing tokens** — debts that must be repaid
- Strangers folded into **Douyou (抖友)** kinship via mutual following
- Refusal to reciprocate reads as **personal disrespect**



"Giving someone a like is like giving them honour. It's the same as treating someone to a meal. If someone treats me to a meal, I have to treat them back."

— Sister Chen, 65



TikTok: reciprocity is discretionary and episodic

- Users **fled** other platforms to escape reciprocal obligation
- Support is affinity-based and **low-pressure**, not a standing rule
- A codified **right not to reciprocate** as part of being 'for you'



"It's like seeing what your friends are up to if your friends were all kind of cool, and you didn't have any obligation to them."

— Judith, 22, London



Douyin: locality hardens into a care infrastructure

- Daily likes become **proof-of-life** for thinning offline networks
- Absence triggers messages, calls, visits — a **welfare check** routine
- Locality made durable through renqing's grammar of attention



"We check on each other every day by liking videos. If someone doesn't post or like for days, we call to see if they're ill."

— Goodluck, 64



TikTok: locality is ephemeral, vitalising offline life

- Modest visibility **sparks** face-to-face recognition in pubs, on streets
- Algorithmic sociality is **complementary**, not constitutive
- Recognition without durable structure — 'pop-up neighborhoods'



Tanja, 20, suburban England: local approached her after seeing her videos on TikTok — a vitalising charge on existing offline social networks.



Life stage activates which moral vocabulary becomes salient



Older · China

Thinning networks → vulnerability → algorithm seized for repair and care.



Younger · UK

Social abundance → attention scarcity → algorithm offers relief and ambient awareness.



Same affordance

Reciprocal liking expands into obligation in one case, minimises into recognition in the other.



Avoiding essentialism

Culture × generation intersect; younger Chinese users may resemble Rhea more than Sister Chen.

✓ **Conclusions**

- Algorithmic sociality is **co-constituted** — by affordances, cultural scripts, and life-stage circumstance (extending Siles 2023)
- Three moral-economic kinds of work: **legitimizing visibility, reciprocating engagement, emplacing community**
- Evidence for **limited** algorithmic effects on cultural values — the world still shapes the platform (Miller et al. 2016)
- We need more **long-term, comparative** research on whether algorithms alter norms at a fundamental level (Matassi & Boczkowski 2022)

Thank you

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